

Week 1, Lesson 2: The Hero's Journey

Detailed 60-minute lesson plan | Ignite English p.12 | 6SI / KS3-aligned

60 minutes

Core text: Ignite p.12

Resource: Hero's Journey video

Lesson Purpose

Introduce the simplified five-stage Hero's Journey used by Ignite: call to adventure; into the unknown; trials and tests; the final challenge; reward and return. Students learn the model, compare it with the linked video, and test it against familiar stories and films. The lesson deliberately treats the Hero's Journey as a useful structural lens rather than a rigid formula.

Learning Objectives

1. Identify and explain the five stages.
2. Apply the stages to a familiar narrative.
3. Discuss how closely real stories follow the model.

Success Criteria

- Correctly sequence all five stages.
- Give a relevant example for at least four stages.
- Use evidence from a known story/film.
- Explain one place where the model fits imperfectly.

British Curriculum Alignment (KS3 / Year 7)

- Reading: understand how the structure of a text contributes to meaning; make connections and comparisons across texts and narratives.
- Spoken English: participate constructively in discussion, present interpretations clearly and respond to alternative viewpoints.
- Vocabulary: use structural terminology accurately when discussing narrative.

Detailed Lesson Sequence

Time	Phase	Teacher actions	Student actions	Evidence / assessment
0-5	Retrieval starter	Display five generic story moments in scrambled order. Ask students to put them in the most logical narrative sequence and justify one choice. Do not name the Hero's Journey yet.	Sequence the moments individually, then compare with a partner.	Check whether students already perceive challenge → struggle → resolution as a recurring pattern.
5-12	Direct teach: Ignite p.12	Reveal p.12. Introduce the five course stages and paraphrase each in student-friendly language. Stress that 'reward and return' may be emotional rather than a literal trip home.	Annotate the five stages on Worksheet 1 or in books. Give a one-sentence paraphrase for each.	Quick cold-call: teacher names a stage; student explains it without reading.
12-16	Memory check	Hide the stage names. Ask pairs to reconstruct all five in order. Reveal and self-correct.	Recall, order and correct the stages.	All five in sequence = secure recall.
16-24	Video watch	Play the linked Hero's Journey video. Before viewing, tell students to note what matches the five-stage model and anything extra/different. After viewing, clarify that Hero's Journey models vary in detail.	Complete Section A of Worksheet 2 while watching.	Look for recognition that the video may use more detailed stages while preserving the same broad arc.
24-34	Guided mapping	Choose one widely known story as a class and map it together. Model cautious reasoning: some events can fit more than one stage. Ask students to justify with events, not just stage labels.	Contribute examples and challenge weak mappings.	Assess use of evidence and structural vocabulary.
34-46	Paired application	Students choose a book, film, game or myth they know well and complete Worksheet 1. Pair partners must agree on the strongest evidence for each stage.	Map the chosen narrative across the five stages.	Formative: accuracy of mapping plus quality of explanation.
46-53	Does the pattern fit?	Use Worksheet 2. Students compare two known stories and rate each as a strong, partial or weak fit. Invite examples of skipped, repeated or blurred stages.	Complete pattern test and discuss where the model breaks down.	Greater depth: recognise the model as a lens, not a law.
53-58	60-second pitch	Pairs give a concise oral explanation: 'Our story does/does not follow the Hero's Journey because...' Require at least three stage references.	Present; listeners may challenge one mapping.	Spoken-language evidence: clarity, justification, responsiveness.
58-60	Exit ticket	Prompt: 'Name one Hero's Journey stage and explain where it appears in a story you know.'	Write a two-sentence answer.	Check accurate terminology + relevant evidence.

Core Knowledge: The Five-Stage Model

1. Call To Adventure - Something disrupts ordinary life and gives the hero a challenge, problem or mission.
2. Into The Unknown - The hero leaves what is familiar and enters a new, uncertain world.
3. Trials And Tests - The hero faces obstacles, learns, fails, adapts and gains allies or knowledge.
4. The Final Challenge - The greatest test forces the hero to risk, choose or confront what matters most.
5. Reward And Return - The hero gains something and returns changed — literally or emotionally.

Questioning Ladder

- Recall: What are the five stages, in order?
- Apply: Where is the 'into the unknown' moment in a story you know?
- Analyse: Why are 'trials and tests' usually plural rather than a single obstacle?
- Evaluate: Does a story need a clear 'return' to count as a Hero's Journey?
- Challenge: Are we discovering a universal story pattern, or forcing stories into a pattern after the fact?

Differentiation

Support

- Keep stage definitions visible.
- Offer a shortlist of familiar narratives.
- Allow oral rehearsal before writing.
- Use sentence stems: 'This fits because...' / 'The hero enters the unknown when...'

Stretch

- Identify stages that overlap or repeat.
- Argue that a chosen story is a weak fit.
- Compare the five-stage Ignite model with the more detailed video model.
- Explain whether a tragic ending can still contain 'reward and return'.

Resources & Teacher Preparation

- Ignite English p.12: The Hero's Journey diagram and Activities 1-2.
- Hero's Journey video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hhk4N9AOoCA>
- Worksheet 1: Hero's Journey Story Mapper.
- Worksheet 2: Does the Pattern Fit? video notes and comparative evaluation.
- IWB toolkit: self-contained click-through lesson with Ignite p.12 embedded and a direct video button.

Pronote Agenda Summary

Unit 1 - The Hero's Journey: Students learned the five-stage Hero's Journey structure (call to adventure, into the unknown, trials and tests, final challenge, reward and return), watched a short explanatory video and applied the pattern to familiar books and films. They then evaluated how closely different stories follow the model.

Lesson Endpoint

Students should leave able to name and explain the five stages and map them onto a familiar narrative. More importantly, they should understand that the Hero's Journey is a structural model that can illuminate patterns across stories without perfectly describing every story.